PRODUCTION BOOK · CHARACTERS + 5-SECOND BEATS

POV: What a Hospital Bill Looks Like at Every Level of Wealth

— From $0 to $1 Billion



14	194	9	~15 min
CHARACTERS	BEATS	CHAPTERS	RUNTIME

Interactive: tap any link to jump, tick the boxes, type notes. Use your PDF app's bookmarks panel to navigate.

Best in Adobe Acrobat Reader, Xodo, Foxit or a desktop browser so the boxes and notes save.

How to use this book

This book works in **two steps**. Every blue word is a link: tap it to jump. The dark bar at the top of every page has Chapter overview and Cast buttons, and your PDF app's **bookmarks panel** lists every chapter and character.

STEP 1 · Build your cast. Generate one reference image per character using the character prompts. Save the images and tick **Reference made**. Attach these references when generating beats so faces stay consistent.

STEP 2 · Generate the beats. Work chapter by chapter from the chapter overview. Each beat is one image on screen, about **5 seconds** of narration. Copy the image prompt, generate, and tick **Image**, **Animated** and **Placed** as you go. Use the notes box at the end of each chapter for anything you want to remember.

Timecodes match the recorded voiceover. Each beat runs until the next one starts. Drop the beats SRT into CapCut or Premiere to place every image on its cue.

Locked visual style

Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail.

Outfit and lighting by level

LEVEL	OUTFIT	LIGHTING
1 · $0	Black hoodie, hood up + gray foam wrist splint	Harsh flickering fluorescent
2 · $5,000	Black hoodie, hood down	Flat washed-out fluorescent
3 · $40,000	Black crewneck sweater	Soft clean daylight
4 · $250,000	Black quarter-zip pullover	Soft warm daylight
5–8 · $2M to $1B	Dark tailored jacket over black tee	Amber → hotel lamps → rich gold
Outro	New stranger (protagonist absent)	Harsh flickering fluorescent

Recurring visual motifs

The white envelope with a small clear plastic window, a name typed in black capitals · the clear plastic hospital ice bag with a blue twist tie and the bill line “ICE BAG ... $91.00” · the bag of frozen peas, $1.89 · the faded red pizza-slice fridge magnet from a closed pizza place · the 14-second piano hold loop, drawn as a ribbon of notes that ends on an unresolved note · the registration tablet with the blank “INSURANCE:” box · the gray foam wrist splint

The money ladder

LEVEL	WHAT THE BILL LOOKS LIKE
1 · $0	An itemized envelope: $4,280 for a sprain, then collections
2 · $5,000	Two envelopes: "THIS IS NOT A BILL", then the $3,140 bill
3 · $40,000	One row you owe: $1,140 of $31,200
4 · $250,000	An email notification, paid with your face in four seconds
5 · $2M	One line a year: annual membership, $15,000
6 · $25M	A row in the family office report, between landscaping and wine
7 · $200M	A claims spreadsheet for 4,000 people: 3,112 ice bags
8 · $1B	No bill at all. You decide which bills stop existing

STEP 1 OF 2

Build your cast

Generate these reference images before any beat. 14 characters. Tick each one when its reference is saved.

CHARACTER	ROLE	APPEARS IN	
The Protagonist	Main character · climbs $0 to $1B	128 beats	☐ Reference made
Mom	His mother · grows frail	10 beats	☐ Reference made
The Registration Clerk	Level 1 · turns the tablet	3 beats	☐ Reference made
The Billing Rep	Level 1 · "Anything else I can help you with?"	3 beats	☐ Reference made
The Landlord	Level 1 · runs your credit	2 beats	☐ Reference made
The Insurance Rep	Level 2 · "I understand your frustration"	2 beats	☐ Reference made
The Rep Whose Voice Lifts	Level 4 · your mother's bill	3 beats	☐ Reference made
The Concierge Doctor	Level 5 · answers in four minutes	5 beats	☐ Reference made
The Director of Patient Experience	Level 6 · naming opportunities	2 beats	☐ Reference made
The CFO	Level 7 · the ice bag slide	3 beats	☐ Reference made
The Household Physician	Level 8 · employed, not billed	2 beats	☐ Reference made
The Hospital CEO	Level 8 · the two-handed handshake	4 beats	☐ Reference made
The Founder	Level 8 · the billing pitch	4 beats	☐ Reference made
The Stranger	Outro · someone, somewhere, right now	7 beats	☐ Reference made

The Protagonist

MAIN CHARACTER · CLIMBS $0 TO $1B



☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet of the protagonist: a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan. Show him five times side by side, full body front view, same face and hair in every pose, deadpan expression: (1) plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint with velcro straps on his right wrist, (2) black hoodie with the hood down, (3) black crewneck sweater, (4) black quarter-zip pullover, (5) dark tailored jacket over a black tee. Plain light-gray background, outfit labels under each pose. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 23, 24, 26, 28, 30, 31, 32, 33, 34, 35, 37, 39, 40, 41, 42, 43, 45, 46, 50, 51, 52, 54, 55, 56, 57, 60, 61, 63, 64, 65, 67, 68, 69, 70, 71, 72, 73, 75, 77, 78, 79, 81, 83, 85, 86, 87, 88, 89, 90, 92, 94, 95, 99, 100, 101, 103, 105, 107, 108, 109, 111, 112, 114, 116, 118, 119, 120, 121, 122, 123, 125, 129, 130, 131, 132, 134, 135, 136, 138, 139, 141, 142, 143, 144, 145, 146, 148, 150, 152, 154, 155, 157, 159, 160, 162, 163, 164, 165, 166, 167, 169, 170, 171, 172, 173, 174, 175, 176, 177, 181

Mom

HIS MOTHER · GROWS FRAIL

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. His mother, shown twice side by side: (1) in her late fifties, warm and practical, gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain, a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse, holding a bag of frozen peas; (2) in her early seventies, thinner and frailer, the same cardigan now too big for her, a gentle tired expression. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

18, 93, 94, 98, 145, 146, 147, 149, 150, 153

The Registration Clerk

LEVEL 1 · TURNS THE TABLET

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The emergency-room registration clerk: a woman in her forties with tight braids pulled back, a maroon scrub top, a hospital lanyard and a flat, tired expression, holding a tablet. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

7, 9, 10

The Billing Rep
LEVEL 1 · "ANYTHING ELSE I CAN HELP YOU WITH?"

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The hospital billing rep: a woman in her thirties with a high ponytail, a telephone headset, a gray cardigan over a white blouse and a fixed, pleasant, scripted smile. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
23, 25, 27

The Landlord
LEVEL 1 · RUNS YOUR CREDIT

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The landlord: a heavyset bald man in his fifties with reading glasses pushed up on his head, a mustard polo shirt and a skeptical raised eyebrow, holding a rental flyer. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
32, 33

The Insurance Rep
LEVEL 2 · "I UNDERSTAND YOUR FRUSTRATION"

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The insurance rep: a man in his thirties with a short beard, a telephone headset, a blue polo shirt with a generic shield logo and a patient, rehearsed expression. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
57, 58

The Rep Whose Voice Lifts
LEVEL 4 · YOUR MOTHER'S BILL

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. A billing rep in her fifties with short gray curls, a telephone headset and a lavender cardigan, shown twice: (1) tired and flat, (2) suddenly bright and eager, sitting up straight. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
95, 96, 97

The Concierge Doctor
LEVEL 5 · ANSWERS IN FOUR MINUTES

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The concierge doctor: a calm, attentive woman in her forties with a sleek black bob, a navy blazer over a gray tee, a stethoscope around her neck and a leather medical bag. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
101, 104, 107, 108, 111

The Director of Patient Experience
LEVEL 6 · NAMING OPPORTUNITIES

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The director of patient experience: an elegant woman in her fifties with a silver pixie cut, a cream blazer, pearl stud earrings and a warm, polished smile, holding an embossed card. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
131, 132

The CFO
LEVEL 7 · THE ICE BAG SLIDE

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT
Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The CFO: a composed woman in her forties with auburn hair in a sleek low bun, a charcoal suit and a tablet, her expression neutral and efficient. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
139, 141, 144

The Household Physician

LEVEL 8 · EMPLOYED, NOT BILLED

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The household physician: a calm man in his fifties with close-cropped gray hair and a trim beard, a white coat over a dark sweater and a small staff badge, holding a soft gel ice pack. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

160, 163

The Hospital CEO

LEVEL 8 · THE TWO-HANDED HANDSHAKE

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The hospital chief executive: a tall man in his sixties with silver swept-back hair, a black tuxedo and a broad practiced smile, both hands extended for a handshake. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

165, 166, 167, 168

The Founder

LEVEL 8 · THE BILLING PITCH

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The startup founder: an energetic man in his early thirties with curly blond hair, a navy blazer over a white tee, slim jeans and white sneakers, holding a phone. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

170, 171, 172, 174

The Stranger

OUTRO · SOMEONE, SOMEWHERE, RIGHT NOW

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The stranger: a young woman in her twenties with a messy dark bun, an oversized faded olive hoodie, worn jeans and a gray foam splint with velcro straps on her right wrist, a tired expression. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

183, 184, 185, 186, 187, 188, 189

Chapter overview

Tap a chapter to jump to its first beat. Tick the box when every beat in the chapter is placed in your edit.

#	CHAPTER	BEATS	STARTS	
1	**Level 1 · $0** The sprain · "Ice bag, $91."	1–36 (36)	00:00	☐ Chapter done
2	**Level 2 · $5,000** The kidney stone · Two envelopes	37–60 (24)	02:43	☐ Chapter done
3	**Level 3 · $40,000** The ankle · The words cost $40,000 a year	61–80 (20)	04:30	☐ Chapter done
4	**Level 4 · $250,000** The envelope disappears · Card on file	81–99 (19)	06:05	☐ Chapter done
5	**Level 5 · $2 Million** Concierge · You pay for the phone number	100–118 (19)	07:40	☐ Chapter done
6	**Level 6 · $25 Million** The bill becomes a spreadsheet row	119–135 (17)	09:08	☐ Chapter done
7	**Level 7 · $200 Million** 4,000 employees · The drawer of envelopes	136–158 (23)	10:29	☐ Chapter done
8	**Level 8 · $1 Billion** The piano loop · Balance, zero	159–182 (24)	12:20	☐ Chapter done
9	**Outro · Somewhere Right Now** A stranger · "Balance due."	183–194 (12)	14:02	☐ Chapter done

CHAPTER 1 OF 9 · BEATS 1–36 · 00:00

Level 1 · $0

The sprain · "Ice bag, $91."

OUTFIT: a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist · LIGHT: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows

001
BEAT

00:00
1.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Level one, zero dollars."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist stands alone on a gray city sidewalk at dawn beside a cracked concrete curb, a delivery-app backpack on his shoulders, a large faded wall sign behind him reading "LEVEL 1 · $0" in stenciled paint, steam rising from a street grate. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: eye-level medium-wide shot, protagonist off-center left. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: bleak, quiet.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
eye-level medium-wide shot, protagonist off-center left	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	bleak, quiet	staring flatly at the curb

002
BEAT

00:01
3.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You step off a curb wrong on the way to a shift you can't miss."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist mid-stumble off a cracked curb edge, one sneaker twisting over the lip, phone with a shift-schedule app flying from his hand, a bus stop and shuttered shops behind him in early-morning gray. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle action shot at curb level. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: sudden, ordinary.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
low-angle action shot at curb level	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	sudden, ordinary	stepping wrong off the curb

003
BEAT

00:05
4.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Your right wrist bends back. A small sound, like a knuckle cracking."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Extreme close-up of the protagonist's right wrist bending backward against the sidewalk as he catches himself, small comic-style crack lines radiating from the joint, his deadpan face blurred in the background. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: sharp, small.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up insert	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	sharp, small	wrist bending back on impact

004
BEAT

00:09
2.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"By noon it's the size of an orange."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist at a cramped fast-food prep counter at noon holding his swollen right wrist up beside a whole orange for comparison, the wrist now the same size and reddish-purple, a coworker in a visor glancing over with alarm. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: absurd, uneasy.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	absurd, uneasy	comparing the wrist to the orange

005
BEAT

00:11
4.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"By nine at night you can't hold a fork. It's a sprain. Not broken."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist at a tiny kitchen table at 9 p.m. trying and failing to grip a fork with his swollen right hand, a bowl of instant noodles going cold, a wall clock reading 9:00, the fork lying on the table. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, slight high angle. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: lonely, stubborn.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, slight high angle	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	lonely, stubborn	the fork slipping from his fingers

006
BEAT

00:15
5.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Just a sprain. The bill is $4,280. You don't know that yet."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
Split frame: left side the protagonist in a plastic emergency-room chair holding his wrist, unaware; right side a ghostly translucent hospital bill floating above him with "$4,280" in large bold red numbers. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: ominous, ironic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	ominous, ironic	sitting unaware beneath the floating bill

007
BEAT

00:21
7.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“At the emergency room, a woman at registration turns a tablet toward you. Financial responsibility form.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Registration Clerk**

IMAGE PROMPT

A cramped emergency-room registration window behind scratched plexiglass, the registration clerk turning a tablet toward the protagonist, the screen titled "FINANCIAL RESPONSIBILITY FORM" with a signature line, a "PLEASE HAVE INSURANCE CARD READY" sign taped to the glass. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the registration clerk is a woman in her forties with tight braids pulled back, a maroon scrub top and a lanyard, her expression flat and tired. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: over-the-shoulder shot from behind the protagonist. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: transactional, cold.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
over-the-shoulder shot from behind the protagonist	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	transactional, cold	the clerk sliding the tablet forward

008
BEAT

00:28
4.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“You sign with your left hand. Your name comes out shaky, like a child wrote it.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the protagonist signing the tablet awkwardly with his left hand, his splinted right hand held against his chest, the stylus producing a wobbly childlike scrawl on the signature line. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert on hands and screen. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: humiliating, small.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert on hands and screen	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	humiliating, small	scrawling the signature

009
BEAT

00:32
4.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“She doesn't look at the signature. She looks at the box that says insurance. Blank.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Registration Clerk**

IMAGE PROMPT

Over the clerk's shoulder at her monitor: she ignores the shaky signature and stares at an empty field labeled "INSURANCE:" which is completely blank and outlined in red. Character notes: the registration clerk is a woman in her forties with tight braids pulled back, a maroon scrub top and a lanyard, her expression flat and tired. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: over-the-shoulder insert on the monitor. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: clinical, sorting.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
over-the-shoulder insert on the monitor	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	clinical, sorting	the clerk's eyes fixed on the blank box

010
BEAT

00:37
4.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“She taps once and the screen moves on. You wait three hours and ten minutes.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Registration Clerk**

IMAGE PROMPT

The clerk tapping her screen once with one finger as a dropdown snaps to "SELF-PAY", and behind the glass the protagonist sits down in a crowded waiting room under a wall clock, a time-lapse ghost of the clock hands sweeping three hours. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the registration clerk is a woman in her forties with tight braids pulled back, a maroon scrub top and a lanyard, her expression flat and tired. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with layered depth. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: indifferent, long.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot with layered depth	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	indifferent, long	the single tap, then the wait

011
BEAT

00:42
4.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“An X-ray. A doctor who stays four minutes and never sits down.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A harried emergency doctor, a balding man in his fifties in rumpled blue scrubs, glancing at an X-ray lightbox showing a wrist while already half-turned toward the curtain, the protagonist sitting on a paper-covered exam bed. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot through a half-open curtain. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: rushed, impersonal.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot through a half-open curtain	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	rushed, impersonal	the doctor leaving mid-sentence

012
BEAT

00:46
4.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“A nurse wraps the wrist in a foam splint and hands you a plastic ice bag.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A tired nurse, a woman in her forties in light-blue scrubs with her hair in a clip, wrapping the protagonist's right wrist in a gray foam splint with velcro straps and placing a clear plastic hospital ice bag with a blue twist tie in his other hand. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: routine, brief.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	routine, brief	the ice bag handed over

013
BEAT

00:50
4.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"It's cold for maybe twenty minutes. You leave it on the seat of the bus."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
Night city bus interior under green-white strip lights, the protagonist stepping off at a stop, the clear plastic ice bag with its blue twist tie left behind on a scuffed orange plastic seat, half-melted. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot from inside the bus. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: forgotten, quiet.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot from inside the bus	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	forgotten, quiet	walking away from the ice bag

014
BEAT

00:55
5.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Eighteen days later, it arrives. A white envelope with a little plastic window."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist at a dented apartment mailbox bank pulling out a single white envelope with a small clear plastic address window, a sticky note on a neighboring box, a wall calendar visible through a doorway with eighteen days crossed off. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: dread, mundane.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	dread, mundane	holding up the envelope

015
BEAT

01:00
4.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Your name sits in the window, typed in capitals, like it's been arrested."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Extreme close-up of the envelope's clear plastic window: a name typed in heavy black capitals behind the plastic, the window's edge casting a thin shadow like bars, a hospital billing return address in the corner. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: cold, arrested.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up insert	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	cold, arrested	the name trapped behind the window

016
BEAT

01:04
12.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Emergency level four, $2,960. X-ray, two views, $611. Splint, $412. Ice bag, $91."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of an itemized hospital bill on cheap white paper with readable lines: "EMERGENCY LEVEL 4 ... $2,960.00", "X-RAY 2 VIEWS ... $611.00", "SPLINT ... $412.00", "ICE BAG ... $91.00", the ice bag line slightly highlighted. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert, slow top-to-bottom framing. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: absurd, clinical.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert, slow top-to-bottom framing	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	absurd, clinical	the lines stacking down the page

017
BEAT

01:16
6.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You read that line four times. Ninety-one dollars. A bag of frozen peas costs $1.89."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist in his kitchen holding the bill in his left hand, staring at it, while an open freezer beside him shows a bag of frozen peas with a bright price sticker "$1.89" next to a floating "$91.00" label. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up, protagonist off-center right. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: absurd, stinging.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up, protagonist off-center right	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	absurd, stinging	rereading the line

018
BEAT

01:23
3.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Your mother told you that on the phone that night. Peas work, she said."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist, Mom

IMAGE PROMPT
Flashback split-screen of a phone call at night: on the left the protagonist on a lumpy couch holding his wrist and a cracked phone, on the right his mother in her small warm kitchen on a landline, holding up a bag of frozen peas like a lesson. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a woman in her sixties with gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: split lighting: cold blue night light on the left, warm yellow kitchen lamp on the right. Mood: tender, practical.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	split lighting: cold blue night light on the left, warm yellow kitchen lamp on the right	tender, practical	the mother raising the peas

019
BEAT

01:27
1.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"They mold to the joint."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a bag of frozen peas molded softly around the protagonist's splinted wrist on a worn couch armrest, frost glittering on the plastic, a remote and a crumpled bill nearby. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: small comfort.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	small comfort	the peas settling over the joint

020
BEAT

01:29
4.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You stick the envelope to the fridge with a magnet from a pizza place that closed."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist pressing the white windowed envelope onto an old white refrigerator with a faded red pizza-slice magnet from a closed pizza place, the magnet's logo half-scratched off, other overdue notices beneath it. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, slight low angle. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: resigned, domestic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, slight low angle	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	resigned, domestic	sliding the magnet into place

021
BEAT

01:33
5.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Then you call the number. Hold music. A soft piano loop, fourteen seconds long."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting on the kitchen floor against the fridge with his phone on speaker, the screen showing "ON HOLD 00:14", a translucent ribbon of soft piano notes curling out of the phone into the air. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, low angle. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: waiting, trapped.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, low angle	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	waiting, trapped	staring at the call timer

022
BEAT

01:38
3.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"It ends on a note that never resolves, then starts again."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
A visual metaphor: a looping ribbon of piano sheet music forming a closed circle in the air of the dim kitchen, the final note dangling unresolved with a question-mark shape, a phone glowing on the floor below. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide metaphor shot. Lighting: dim kitchen with a cold blue phone glow. Mood: hypnotic, circular.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide metaphor shot	dim kitchen with a cold blue phone glow	hypnotic, circular	the music circling back to the start

023
BEAT

01:42
5.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You hear it eleven times before a person answers. She's polite. She offers a plan."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist, The Billing Rep

IMAGE PROMPT
Split-screen: the protagonist on the kitchen floor with the phone at "ON HOLD 02:34", and a fluorescent call-center cubicle where the billing rep speaks politely into her headset with a payment-plan script open on her screen. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the billing rep is a woman in her thirties with a high ponytail, a telephone headset and a gray cardigan, wearing a fixed pleasant smile. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: polite, hollow.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	polite, hollow	the rep reading from her screen

024
BEAT

01:47
5.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"$180 a month for twenty-four months. You ask about financial assistance."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of the protagonist's phone showing a payment plan text: "$180/month × 24 months", beside it his left hand holding the bill, the word "Financial Assistance?" typed into a notes app. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert on phone and bill. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: heavy, hopeful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert on phone and bill	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	heavy, hopeful	thumb hovering over the screen

025
BEAT

01:53
4.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“She says sure, and lists the documents. Three months of bank statements.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Billing Rep**

IMAGE PROMPT

The billing rep at her call-center desk reading a checklist on her monitor titled "REQUIRED DOCUMENTS" with "3 months of bank statements" at the top, other agents in headsets behind her in gray cubicles. Character notes: the billing rep is a woman in her thirties with a high ponytail, a telephone headset and a gray cardigan, wearing a fixed pleasant smile. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot of the rep. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: bureaucratic, flat.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot of the rep	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	bureaucratic, flat	reading the list aloud

026
BEAT

01:57
3.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“You get paid on a card. You don't have a bank.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist holding up a plastic prepaid pay card with a generic logo in front of a closed bank branch window, his reflection in the glass, no checkbook, no bank card. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: excluded, quiet.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	excluded, quiet	holding up the pay card

027
BEAT

02:00
4.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“She says, is there anything else I can help you with today? Her voice doesn't change.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Billing Rep**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the billing rep's face with a perfectly even, pleasant, scripted expression, a speech bubble reading "Is there anything else I can help you with today?", a script page taped beside her monitor. Character notes: the billing rep is a woman in her thirties with a high ponytail, a telephone headset and a gray cardigan, wearing a fixed pleasant smile. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: polite, numbing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	polite, numbing	smiling the same smile

028
BEAT

02:05
2.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"That's what stays with you. Not cruelty."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist lowering the phone slowly from his ear in the dim kitchen, the pizza magnet and envelope on the fridge behind him, his face unreadable. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up, protagonist off-center left. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: wounded, quiet.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up, protagonist off-center left	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	wounded, quiet	lowering the phone

029
BEAT

02:07
2.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Just a script that doesn't have a page for you."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: a thick binder of call-center scripts lying open on a desk, its tabs labeled "PAYMENT PLAN", "COLLECTIONS", "CLOSING", with an empty gap where a page has been torn out. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: indifferent, empty.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	indifferent, empty	pages fluttering past the gap

030
BEAT

02:10
4.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You miss the third payment by two days. A $35 late fee."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist looking at a calendar on his phone where a payment due date is two days in the past, a red notification banner reading "LATE FEE: $35.00". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up over-the-shoulder on the phone. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: small, punishing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up over-the-shoulder on the phone	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	small, punishing	the banner sliding down

031
BEAT

02:15
6.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Then a different envelope, from a company you've never heard of. Collections. Same window. Same capitals."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist at his mailbox holding a second white envelope with an identical plastic window and capital-letter name, this one stamped with a generic collections agency logo and "FINAL NOTICE" in red. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: escalating, cold.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	escalating, cold	comparing the two envelopes

032
BEAT

02:21
5.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Eight months later, you apply for a cheaper apartment. The landlord runs your credit."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Landlord**

IMAGE PROMPT
A small rental office with a "UNIT FOR RENT" flyer on a corkboard, the protagonist across the desk from the landlord, who types his details into an old computer. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the landlord is a heavyset bald man in his fifties with reading glasses pushed up on his head and a mustard polo shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: hopeful, nervous.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	hopeful, nervous	the landlord typing

033
BEAT

02:26
4.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"He looks at the screen. Then at you. Then he says the unit just got rented."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Landlord**

IMAGE PROMPT
The landlord looking from his monitor, which shows a low red credit score, up to the protagonist, his eyebrows lifting, then turning the "UNIT FOR RENT" flyer face down. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the landlord is a heavyset bald man in his fifties with reading glasses pushed up on his head and a mustard polo shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: over-the-shoulder shot from behind the landlord. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: judging, final.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
over-the-shoulder shot from behind the landlord	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	judging, final	flipping the flyer over

034
BEAT

02:31
4.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Your wrist healed in five weeks. The bill is still on your record."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Split frame: left, the protagonist's healed wrist flexing freely; right, a credit report screen with a red line item reading "MEDICAL COLLECTION · $4,280 · OPEN". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: unfair, lingering.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	unfair, lingering	the wrist moving, the record unchanged

035
BEAT

02:35
4.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"The first rule of the hospital bill. At zero, the bill isn't a request."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist standing in his kitchen facing the fridge, the envelope pinned under the pizza magnet, the bill drawn like a court summons with a faint gavel shadow across it. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up and a gray foam splint on his right wrist, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: grim, symbolic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	grim, symbolic	staring at the summons

036
BEAT

02:40
3.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"It's a sentence. Paid in installments."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: the hospital bill unrolling into a long chain of small envelopes, each stamped "INSTALLMENT", stretching out of the kitchen and down a dim hallway like a sentence being served. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide metaphor shot. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: crushing, cold.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide metaphor shot	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	crushing, cold	the chain stretching on

Notes · Chapter 1

CHAPTER 2 OF 9 · BEATS 37–60 · 02:43

Level 2 · $5,000

The kidney stone · Two envelopes

OUTFIT: a plain black hoodie with the hood down · LIGHT: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones

037
BEAT

02:43
8.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Level two, $5,000. You have insurance now. The cheap plan. A $7,500 deductible."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in a plain black hoodie with the hood down holding up a thin plastic insurance card at a bus stop, a large wall poster behind him reading "LEVEL 2 · $5,000", the card stamped "DEDUCTIBLE $7,500". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, protagonist off-center left. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: cautiously hopeful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, protagonist off-center left	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	cautiously hopeful	inspecting the card

038
BEAT

02:51
5.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Which means the card in your wallet is mostly a promise about other people's money."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: a wallet open on a table with the insurance card inside, and from the card a translucent thought cloud shows other people's money in a vault, behind a glass wall, out of reach. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor insert. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: hollow, ironic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up metaphor insert	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	hollow, ironic	the card glowing faintly

039
BEAT

02:56
2.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"A kidney stone wakes you at 4 a.m."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist curled on his side in bed at 4 a.m., clutching his lower back, the alarm clock glowing "4:00 AM", twisted sheets, blue night light through the window blinds. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, high angle. Lighting: cold blue night light through blinds. Mood: agonizing, lonely.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, high angle	cold blue night light through blinds	agonizing, lonely	curled in pain

040
BEAT

02:58
5.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Pain so complete you can't remember being anything else. A CT scan. Fluids.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A busy emergency bay: the protagonist on a gurney with an IV line, a CT scanner ring visible in the next room through a doorway, a bag of fluids hanging from a pole. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: clinical, overwhelming.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	clinical, overwhelming	lying still under the IV

041
BEAT

03:04
4.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“A prescription you fill and ration. You've already learned to fear the door.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at home cutting pills in half with a kitchen knife on a cutting board next to an orange prescription bottle, a glance toward the front door with a shadow under it. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on hands, protagonist's face soft in the background. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: careful, fearful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up on hands, protagonist's face soft in the background	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	careful, fearful	halving a pill

042
BEAT

03:08
2.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Last month your throat burned for a week.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Flashback of the protagonist on the couch a month earlier wrapped in a blanket, holding his red sore throat, a box of tissues and a mug of tea, a calendar showing seven days crossed out. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: desaturated, cold flashback light. Mood: miserable, enduring.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	desaturated, cold flashback light	miserable, enduring	touching his throat

043
BEAT

03:10
2.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You called urgent care to ask the price first."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on the phone outside a strip-mall urgent care, its sign reading "URGENT CARE · WALK-INS WELCOME", looking through the glass at a waiting room. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, protagonist off-center right. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: hopeful, wary.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, protagonist off-center right	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	hopeful, wary	asking the price

044
BEAT

03:13
3.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"The woman said she couldn't tell you until after the visit."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Inside the urgent care, a front-desk worker, a young woman in purple scrubs with a headset, shrugging apologetically into her phone beside a sign reading "PRICES DETERMINED AFTER VISIT". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on the worker. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: absurd, evasive.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot on the worker	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	absurd, evasive	shrugging

045
BEAT

03:16
4.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"So you gargled salt water for nine days and called it a choice."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at a bathroom mirror gargling salt water, a canister of table salt on the sink, a tally of nine marks drawn in marker on the mirror's corner. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up via mirror reflection. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: stubborn, bleak.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up via mirror reflection	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	stubborn, bleak	gargling

046
BEAT

03:20
1.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"This time, two envelopes come."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at his mailbox pulling out two white windowed envelopes at once, holding one in each hand, eyes flicking between them. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: uneasy.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	uneasy	holding two envelopes

047
BEAT

03:22
3.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"The first says, in bold across the top, THIS IS NOT A BILL."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of an insurance statement with bold black text across the top reading "THIS IS NOT A BILL", the protagonist's thumb pressing the corner of the page. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: bureaucratic, false calm.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	bureaucratic, false calm	the header filling the frame

048
BEAT

03:25
8.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"It shows the hospital charged $8,900. Your insurer negotiated it down to $3,140."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of the statement's columns: "Amount billed: $8,900.00", a red strike-through, "Allowed amount: $3,140.00", printed in small dense type. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: confusing, clinical.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up insert	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	confusing, clinical	numbers crossed out and replaced

049
BEAT

03:34
2.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"A column of numbers people agreed on without you."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Visual metaphor: two faceless office workers in suits shaking hands across a conference table covered in paper columns, a small empty chair at the end of the table labeled "PATIENT". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide metaphor shot. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: excluded, cold.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide metaphor shot	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	excluded, cold	the handshake over the empty chair

050
BEAT

03:37
5.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"And at the bottom, the amount the plan paid. Zero. The second envelope is the bill."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of the bottom of the statement showing "Plan paid: $0.00", then the protagonist slowly tearing open the second white envelope with the plastic window. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert, two-part composition. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: sinking.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert, two-part composition	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	sinking	opening the second envelope

051
BEAT

03:42
7.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"$3,140. All yours. You never get close to the deductible. Nobody on this plan does."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist at his tiny table holding a bill reading "PATIENT RESPONSIBILITY: $3,140.00", beside it a progress bar labeled "DEDUCTIBLE" barely filled, "$0 of $7,500 met". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: defeated, quiet.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	defeated, quiet	staring at the empty progress bar

052
BEAT

03:50
4.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"The stone was four millimeters. The bill is a month of rent. You scan the lines."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
Split frame: a tiny four-millimeter kidney stone in a specimen cup on the left, and on the right a rent check made out for "$3,140" taking up the whole frame. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: absurd, heavy.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	absurd, heavy	comparing the stone to the rent

053
BEAT

03:55
4.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"There it is. Ice bag, $91. You don't remember an ice bag."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of the second bill's itemization with one line circled in pencil: "ICE BAG ... $91.00", a clear plastic hospital ice bag with a blue twist tie drawn faintly beside it like a ghost. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: ironic, recurring.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	ironic, recurring	the pencil circling the line

054
BEAT

03:59
2.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You were curled on a gurney with your eyes closed."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
Flashback: the protagonist curled on a gurney with his eyes squeezed shut in a dim emergency bay, nurses moving blurrily around him, no ice bag visible anywhere. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, high angle. Lighting: desaturated, cold flashback light. Mood: hazy, uncertain.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, high angle	desaturated, cold flashback light	hazy, uncertain	eyes closed in pain

055
BEAT

04:02
4.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Maybe they put one on your back. Maybe they didn't. You call the insurer.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting on his couch dialing an insurance number printed on the back of his card, the bill in his lap, a question mark drawn faintly over a translucent ice bag above him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: doubtful, tired.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	doubtful, tired	dialing the number

056
BEAT

04:06
5.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Fourteen seconds of piano. You can hum it now. You know exactly where it loops.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist lying on the couch with the phone on his chest, eyes closed, humming along, a ribbon of piano notes looping in a circle above his face with the same unresolved final note. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, overhead angle. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: weary, familiar.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, overhead angle	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	weary, familiar	humming the loop

057
BEAT

04:11
5.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“A man answers. You explain. He says, I understand your frustration. You explain again.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Insurance Rep**

IMAGE PROMPT

Split-screen: the protagonist explaining with his hands into the phone, and the insurance rep in a cubicle wearing a headset, a sticky note on his monitor reading "EMPATHY STATEMENT: I understand your frustration". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the insurance rep is a man in his thirties with a short beard, a telephone headset and a blue polo shirt with a generic shield logo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: scripted, circular.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	scripted, circular	the rep glancing at the sticky note

058
BEAT

04:16
3.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“He says it again, the same four words, the same pitch,”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Insurance Rep**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the insurance rep's mouth repeating the same words, with an identical speech bubble copied three times in a row: "I understand your frustration". Character notes: the insurance rep is a man in his thirties with a short beard, a telephone headset and a blue polo shirt with a generic shield logo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: robotic, maddening.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	robotic, maddening	the bubbles repeating

059
BEAT
04:19
5.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“like a key turning in a lock that doesn't open. At $5,000, you're not uninsured.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Visual metaphor: a key turning endlessly in a heavy steel lock that never opens, the lock stamped with an insurance shield logo, a faint "$5,000" price tag hanging from it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up metaphor. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: futile, locked.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up metaphor	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	futile, locked	the key turning

060
BEAT
04:25
4.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“You're underinsured. The only difference is the second envelope.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist standing at the fridge with two envelopes pinned under the pizza magnet, one labeled "NOT A BILL", one labeled "BILL". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood down, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, protagonist off-center left. Lighting: flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones. Mood: underinsured, wry.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, protagonist off-center left	flat cool fluorescent light, washed-out tones	underinsured, wry	looking at both envelopes

Notes · Chapter 2

CHAPTER 3 OF 9 · BEATS 61–80 · 04:30

Level 3 · $40,000

The ankle · The words cost $40,000 a year

OUTFIT: a black crewneck sweater · LIGHT: soft clean daylight

061
BEAT

04:30
4.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Level three, $40,000. A real job. A real plan."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in a black crewneck sweater walking into a bright open-plan office with a company badge on a lanyard, a framed motivational print on the wall reading "LEVEL 3 · $40,000". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: steady, new.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	soft clean daylight	steady, new	walking in with coffee

062
BEAT

04:34
4.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"A $500 deductible and a ceiling you can actually see."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of an employee benefits booklet open to a page: "DEDUCTIBLE: $500" and "OUT-OF-POCKET MAXIMUM: $2,000" with a clear horizontal ceiling line drawn across a chart. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: reassuring.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	soft clean daylight	reassuring	the ceiling line glowing

063
BEAT

04:39
4.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You break your ankle playing pickup basketball on a Saturday. Surgery Monday."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

An outdoor pickup basketball court on a sunny Saturday, the protagonist in a black crewneck mid-fall with his ankle rolled, friends in tank tops rushing toward him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: dynamic medium-wide action shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: sudden, painful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
dynamic medium-wide action shot	soft clean daylight	sudden, painful	landing badly

064
BEAT
04:43
3.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Two screws and a plate. You're scared of the surgery.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist in a hospital gown in a pre-op bay looking at an X-ray on a monitor showing two screws and a metal plate in an ankle, his face flat but his fingers gripping the sheet. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: nervous.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	soft clean daylight	nervous	staring at the X-ray

065
BEAT
04:47
4.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Then you realize you're more scared of the envelope. It comes. Same white paper.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist on crutches at his building's mailbox holding a white envelope with a small plastic window, the same kind as before, his jaw tight. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: anxious, conditioned.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft clean daylight	anxious, conditioned	holding the envelope at arm's length

066
BEAT
04:51
10.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Same little window. But the math inside is different now. Total charges, $31,200. Plan paid, $30,060.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of a clean, well-designed statement with three readable rows: "Total charges: $31,200.00", "Plan paid: $30,060.00", the plan-paid row highlighted. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: relief.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	soft clean daylight	relief	the rows coming into focus

067
BEAT
05:01
7.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“You owe, $1,140. You stare at the middle number. Thirty thousand dollars somebody else handled.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist at a sunny kitchen table with his leg in a boot, the statement in hand, "You owe: $1,140.00" at the bottom, his finger resting on the middle "$30,060.00" line. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: stunned, quiet.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	soft clean daylight	stunned, quiet	tracing the middle number

068
BEAT

05:09
4.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"At level one, you'd have carried that for a decade. Here it's just a row."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Split frame: on the left a faded memory of the protagonist in a black hoodie carrying a massive stack of envelopes up a staircase; on the right the present protagonist holding a single slim sheet. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: contrast, relief.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	soft clean daylight	contrast, relief	holding the single sheet

069
BEAT

05:13
6.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Then a surprise. A separate bill from an anesthesia group you never met. $2,400."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist pulling a surprise envelope from the mailbox, the letterhead reading a generic "ANESTHESIA ASSOCIATES", and the total "$2,400.00" in bold. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up over-the-shoulder. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: shock, deja vu.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up over-the-shoulder	soft clean daylight	shock, deja vu	his grip tightening

070
BEAT

05:20
3.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Your stomach drops out of habit. But you've learned the words now."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on his couch with a laptop open to a consumer rights page, the key phrases highlighted in yellow, his posture straightening. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: reflexive fear turning to resolve.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft clean daylight	reflexive fear turning to resolve	reading the screen

071
BEAT

05:23
4.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You read them off a website and say them on the phone. The rep pauses."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on the phone, reading carefully from his laptop screen, while across a split frame a billing rep, a woman in her thirties with box braids and a headset, pauses with her finger above her keyboard. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: quietly powerful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	soft clean daylight	quietly powerful	the rep freezing mid-type

072
BEAT

05:27
2.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Puts you on hold. Six minutes of piano.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist on hold, phone on speaker on the coffee table showing "ON HOLD 06:00", a short loop of piano notes drifting up, his boot propped on a cushion. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: patient, informed.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft clean daylight	patient, informed	waiting calmly

073
BEAT

05:30
3.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“It sounds shorter when you know how it ends. She comes back.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist leaning back on the couch with half a smile, the looping piano ribbon now shorter and lighter, the call timer stopping. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: knowing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	soft clean daylight	knowing	the phone screen changing to "CONNECTED"

074
BEAT

05:34
3.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“The bill has been withdrawn. Sorry for the confusion.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of an email on a laptop screen: "Your balance with Anesthesia Associates has been adjusted to $0.00. We apologize for the confusion.". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: anticlimactic, revealing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	soft clean daylight	anticlimactic, revealing	the balance dropping to zero

075
BEAT

05:37
3.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Nobody taught you that sentence at level one. That's the thing.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
Flashback of the protagonist in a black hoodie on the kitchen floor at level one, phone to his ear, with a blank empty speech bubble floating above him where the words should be. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, desaturated. Lighting: desaturated, cold flashback light. Mood: regretful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, desaturated	desaturated, cold flashback light	regretful	holding the silent phone

076
BEAT
05:41
5.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"The words existed the whole time. They just cost $40,000 a year to learn."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Visual metaphor: a glass display case in a store containing a small book titled "THE WORDS", with a price tag reading "$40,000 / year", a velvet rope in front of it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: exclusive, ironic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up metaphor insert	soft clean daylight	exclusive, ironic	the price tag swinging

077
BEAT
05:46
4.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Your manager approves two weeks of paid leave without looking up from her screen."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
An office cubicle where the protagonist's manager, a cheerful woman in her forties with red curly hair and a cardigan, clicks "APPROVE" on a leave request reading "PAID LEAVE: 2 WEEKS" without looking up, the protagonist on crutches beside her desk. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: easy, generous.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft clean daylight	easy, generous	the click without a glance

078
BEAT
05:51
4.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"At level one, two weeks off would have cost more than the surgery."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
Split frame: the present protagonist resting with his boot up and a book; a desaturated level-one version of him in a hoodie counting crumpled bills on a kitchen table. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: soft clean daylight on one side, desaturated cold light on the other. Mood: contrast.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	soft clean daylight on one side, desaturated cold light on the other	contrast	resting versus counting

079
BEAT
05:55
4.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You put the envelope on the fridge anyway. Same magnet. Old instinct."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist in his black crewneck pinning the opened, paid statement to his fridge under the same faded red pizza-slice magnet, now in a brighter, nicer kitchen. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: habitual, tender.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	soft clean daylight	habitual, tender	pressing the magnet down

080
BEAT

06:00
5.6s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

> *“At $40,000, the bill stops being a threat. It becomes paperwork.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: a menacing envelope with sharp teeth shrinking into a plain flat manila folder labeled "PAPERWORK" in a filing drawer. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphor close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: calm, deflated.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphor close-up	soft clean daylight	calm, deflated	the envelope flattening

Notes · Chapter 3

CHAPTER 4 OF 9 · BEATS 81–99 · 06:05

Level 4 · $250,000

The envelope disappears · Card on file

OUTFIT: a black quarter-zip pullover · LIGHT: soft warm daylight

081
BEAT
06:05
6.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Level four, $250,000. The envelope disappears. The bill comes as an email now."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in a black quarter-zip pullover in a bright apartment with large windows, a white envelope with a plastic window dissolving into pixels in his hand, a framed print on the wall reading "LEVEL 4 · $250,000". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, protagonist off-center left. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: light, modern.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, protagonist off-center left	soft warm daylight	light, modern	the envelope pixelating away

082
BEAT
06:12
1.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Your statement is ready."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a smartphone lock screen showing an email notification: "Your statement is ready. View in patient portal.", a coffee cup steaming beside it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: frictionless.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	soft warm daylight	frictionless	the notification appearing

083
BEAT
06:14
4.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You open the patient portal and pay with your face in four seconds."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist holding his phone up to his face as a face-recognition frame scans him, a patient portal screen showing a "PAY NOW" button and a four-second countdown. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up over the shoulder. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: effortless.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up over the shoulder	soft warm daylight	effortless	the face scan

084
BEAT
06:18
4.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You don't read the lines. You just watch the balance turn green."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the portal screen: the balance figure turning from gray to green with a check mark and "PAID IN FULL", the itemized lines collapsed and unread. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: detached, smooth.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up insert	soft warm daylight	detached, smooth	the balance turning green

085
BEAT
06:22
6.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You need an MRI for your lower back. You find out the hospital charges $3,200."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist at a standing desk comparing two browser tabs: "HOSPITAL MRI · $3,200" and "IMAGING CENTER · $450 CASH", his hand on his lower back. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: calculating.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	soft warm daylight	calculating	comparing prices

086
BEAT
06:28
5.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"An imaging center across town does it for $450 cash. You pay cash."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
A clean modern imaging center lobby with potted plants and a cash price board reading "MRI LUMBAR SPINE · $450", the protagonist handing over a card. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: efficient.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	soft warm daylight	efficient	paying at the counter

087
BEAT
06:34
5.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"It's faster than arguing. The receptionist asks, card on file? You have a card on file."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
A friendly receptionist, a young man with a neat fade haircut and a light-gray polo, gesturing to a screen prompt "USE CARD ON FILE?" while the protagonist nods. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot over the counter. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: smooth, upgraded.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot over the counter	soft warm daylight	smooth, upgraded	the receptionist smiling

088
BEAT
06:40
3.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You didn't know you'd become a person with a card on file."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist catching his reflection in the imaging center's glass door, a glowing translucent credit card hovering over his chest like a name tag. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up via reflection. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: self-aware, quiet.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up via reflection	soft warm daylight	self-aware, quiet	looking at his reflection

089
BEAT

06:43
6.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Later, out of curiosity, you open an old visit in the portal. Itemized. Ice bag, $91."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at a marble kitchen island at night scrolling an old itemized visit in the portal on a tablet, the line "ICE BAG ... $91.00" enlarged on screen. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: over-the-shoulder close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: curious, ironic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
over-the-shoulder close-up	soft warm daylight	curious, ironic	zooming in on the line

090
BEAT

06:50
4.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You laugh out loud in your kitchen. Then you close the tab. You don't dispute it."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist laughing once, alone, in his warm modern kitchen, then tapping the tablet's close button, the ice bag line disappearing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: bitter amusement.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft warm daylight	bitter amusement	closing the tab

091
BEAT

06:55
4.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Ninety-one dollars isn't worth fourteen seconds of piano. That's when you notice it."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: a balance scale with a $91 price tag on one side and a tiny looping ribbon of piano notes on the other, the scale tipping slowly toward the music. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphor close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: cynical, weighing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphor close-up	soft warm daylight	cynical, weighing	the scale tipping

092
BEAT

07:00
3.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"The number didn't change. You did. Your mother calls that week."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist looking at his reflection in a dark window, where his reflection is the old level-one version of him in a black hoodie and splint, the $91 price tag floating unchanged between them. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: cool blue night window light with a warm kitchen glow behind. Mood: unsettling realization.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	cool blue night window light with a warm kitchen glow behind	unsettling realization	staring at the reflection

093
BEAT

07:03
4.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"She's on the phone with the hospital about a fall she took in the parking lot."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mom**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist's mother in a cramped older kitchen with a landline phone cord stretched across the room, a small bandage on her elbow, a hospital bill in her hand. Character notes: his mother is a woman in her sixties with gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim yellow kitchen light, slightly faded. Mood: weary, stubborn.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	dim yellow kitchen light, slightly faded	weary, stubborn	holding the receiver

094
BEAT

07:07
4.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"She's been on hold for forty minutes. You tell her to give you the account number."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, Mom**

IMAGE PROMPT
Split-screen phone call: his mother sitting on a kitchen stool with "ON HOLD 40:12" on an old caller display, and the protagonist on his couch holding out his hand as if reaching through the screen for the bill. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a woman in her sixties with gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: protective.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	soft warm daylight	protective	asking for the account number

095
BEAT

07:12
3.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You call. The loop starts. A woman picks up, tired, flat."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Rep Whose Voice Lifts**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist on the phone in his bright living room, a ribbon of looping piano notes, and in a split frame a billing rep, a woman in her fifties with short gray curls and a headset, picking up with a tired flat face. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the billing rep is a woman in her fifties with short gray curls, a telephone headset and a lavender cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: routine.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	soft warm daylight	routine	the rep answering flatly

096
BEAT

07:16
4.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You say, I'd like to pay the full balance. Her voice lifts half an octave."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Rep Whose Voice Lifts**

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of the same billing rep straightening in her chair, eyebrows lifting, her face suddenly brightening as a small rising musical note floats from her headset. Character notes: the billing rep is a woman in her fifties with short gray curls, a telephone headset and a lavender cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: status shift.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	soft warm daylight	status shift	her posture lifting

097
BEAT
07:20
7.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Of course. Absolutely. Let me pull that up for you. Thirty seconds, and it's gone. $2,870."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Rep Whose Voice Lifts**

IMAGE PROMPT

The rep typing quickly with a big helpful smile, her screen showing "BALANCE $2,870.00 → PAID", a confetti-like checkmark animation on the monitor. Character notes: the billing rep is a woman in her fifties with short gray curls, a telephone headset and a lavender cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: eager, transactional.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	soft warm daylight	eager, transactional	the balance clearing

098
BEAT
07:27
4.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Your mother sends you a photo of the paid statement. She stuck it to her fridge."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mom**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's mother proudly pressing the paid statement onto her old fridge with a magnet, snapping a photo of it with a flip phone, a faint smile. Character notes: his mother is a woman in her sixties with gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: tender, proud.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft warm daylight	tender, proud	taking the photo

099
BEAT
07:32
7.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"At $250,000, a hospital bill is a notification. You swipe it away like the weather."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist swiping away a notification on a large phone screen like a weather alert, a tiny cloud icon next to "Hospital statement paid" sliding off the screen. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on hand and phone. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: casual, distant.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up on hand and phone	soft warm daylight	casual, distant	the swipe

Notes · Chapter 4

CHAPTER 5 OF 9 · BEATS 100–118 · 07:40

Level 5 · $2 Million

Concierge · You pay for the phone number

OUTFIT: a dark tailored jacket over a black tee · LIGHT: warm natural light with amber accents

100
BEAT
07:40
6.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Level five, $2 million. You stop paying for care. You pay for access. A concierge practice."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in a dark tailored jacket over a black tee in an elegant private medical lounge with soft chairs and orchids, a brass plaque reading "LEVEL 5 · $2,000,000" by a frosted door. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: exclusive, calm.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm natural light with amber accents	exclusive, calm	walking past the plaque

101
BEAT
07:46
5.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"$15,000 a year. Your doctor has three hundred patients and one of them is you."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Concierge Doctor**

IMAGE PROMPT

A small, quiet concierge practice waiting area with only one chair occupied, the concierge doctor greeting the protagonist by name in the doorway. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the concierge doctor is a calm woman in her forties with a sleek black bob, a navy blazer over a gray tee and a stethoscope around her neck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: personal, rare.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm natural light with amber accents	personal, rare	the doctor smiling in welcome

102
BEAT
07:52
6.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"The invoice arrives once, in January. One line. Annual membership. No codes. No ice bags."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a thick cream invoice card with a single printed line: "ANNUAL MEMBERSHIP ... $15,000.00", no codes, no itemization, a calendar page for January beside it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: clean, minimal.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	warm natural light with amber accents	clean, minimal	the single line

103
BEAT

07:59
5.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"It's 2 a.m. and your chest feels tight. You text. She answers in four minutes."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist sitting up in a dark luxury bedroom at 2 a.m. holding his chest, his phone screen showing a text sent to his doctor and her reply arriving with a "4 min" timestamp. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: dim blue night light with a single warm bedside lamp. Mood: anxious, answered.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	dim blue night light with a single warm bedside lamp	anxious, answered	reading the reply

104
BEAT

08:04
2.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"She asks three questions. It's anxiety."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Concierge Doctor**

IMAGE PROMPT
The concierge doctor in a soft sweater at her home kitchen counter at night, calmly texting on her phone, three short questions visible in speech bubbles. Character notes: the concierge doctor is a calm woman in her forties with a sleek black bob, a navy blazer over a gray tee and a stethoscope around her neck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: soft warm kitchen pendant light at night. Mood: calm, attentive.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	soft warm kitchen pendant light at night	calm, attentive	typing the questions

105
BEAT

08:06
3.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"She tells you to breathe, and stays on the phone until you do."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist on the edge of the bed breathing slowly, phone on speaker on the nightstand with "CALL 00:18:42", the room gradually relaxing in warm lamp light. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: soothing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm natural light with amber accents	soothing	breathing out

106
BEAT

08:10
5.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"There's no bill for that call. It's already been paid. Months ago. Before anything hurt."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of the cream membership invoice from January, a red "PAID" stamp on it, and a tiny clock in the corner showing the date months earlier. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: prepaid calm.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	warm natural light with amber accents	prepaid calm	the stamp glinting

107
BEAT

08:15
2.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"In March she makes a house call for a fever."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Concierge Doctor**

IMAGE PROMPT

The concierge doctor arriving at the protagonist's large front door in March carrying a leather medical bag, the protagonist wrapped in a blanket opening it. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the concierge doctor is a calm woman in her forties with a sleek black bob, a navy blazer over a gray tee and a stethoscope around her neck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: personal, unhurried.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm natural light with amber accents	personal, unhurried	the doctor stepping inside

108
BEAT

08:18
2.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"She sits on the arm of your couch for fifty minutes."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Concierge Doctor**

IMAGE PROMPT

The concierge doctor sitting relaxed on the arm of a large sofa, listening to the protagonist, a clock on the wall showing fifty minutes have passed. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the concierge doctor is a calm woman in her forties with a sleek black bob, a navy blazer over a gray tee and a stethoscope around her neck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: unhurried, human.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm natural light with amber accents	unhurried, human	the doctor listening

109
BEAT

08:21
5.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"At level one, a doctor stayed four minutes and never sat down. Same degree. Same training."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Split frame: on the left, the level-one doctor in rumpled scrubs walking out of a curtain after four minutes, a stopwatch reading 4:00; on the right, the concierge doctor seated on the sofa arm with a stopwatch reading 50:00. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: cold fluorescent on the left, warm amber on the right. Mood: stark contrast.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	cold fluorescent on the left, warm amber on the right	stark contrast	the two stopwatches

110
BEAT

08:26
4.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"The only thing that changed is which side of the retainer you're on."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: the same stethoscope lying on two different surfaces, one a cold metal ER counter, one a warm wooden side table, divided by a glowing line labeled "RETAINER". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphor close-up. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: ironic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphor close-up	warm natural light with amber accents	ironic	the glowing line between them

111
BEAT
08:31
4.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"When you do need a hospital, she calls ahead. A form appears pre-filled."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist, The Concierge Doctor

IMAGE PROMPT
The concierge doctor on her phone in a hallway, and the protagonist arriving at a hospital where a tablet already shows a pre-filled form with a green check mark. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the concierge doctor is a calm woman in her forties with a sleek black bob, a navy blazer over a gray tee and a stethoscope around her neck. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: smooth, arranged.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm natural light with amber accents	smooth, arranged	the form already complete

112
BEAT
08:35
7.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Nobody turns a tablet toward you. Nobody watches the insurance box. Her assistant emails afterward."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
A hospital registration counter with no one behind it and an unused tablet face down, the protagonist walking past it, a "SELF-PAY" dropdown nowhere in sight. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: frictionless.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm natural light with amber accents	frictionless	walking past the counter

113
BEAT
08:42
3.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Would you like us to send the statement directly to your accountant?"*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of a laptop email reading "Would you like us to send the statement directly to your accountant?" with a polite signature from a concierge practice assistant. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: assumptive, upscale.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	warm natural light with amber accents	assumptive, upscale	the cursor over "Yes"

114
BEAT
08:45
4.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"It's the first time anyone has assumed you have an accountant. You say yes."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist reading the email in a sunlit study, one eyebrow slightly raised, then clicking "Yes", a framed photo of his mother on the desk. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: quietly surprised.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	warm natural light with amber accents	quietly surprised	clicking yes

115
BEAT
08:50
4.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You don't see the itemization. You'll never know if there was an ice bag."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
A sealed envelope sliding into a briefcase belonging to an unseen accountant, the itemization hidden, a faint outline of an ice bag visible through the paper. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor insert. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: unknown.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up metaphor insert	warm natural light with amber accents	unknown	the envelope disappearing

116
BEAT
08:54
3.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You realize something. At level one, you were billed for every minute."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
Split frame: a desaturated level-one protagonist under a ticking taxi-style meter labeled "$ PER MINUTE", and the present protagonist in a calm lounge with no meter. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: cold fluorescent on the left, warm amber on the right. Mood: reflective.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	cold fluorescent on the left, warm amber on the right	reflective	the meter ticking on one side

117
BEAT
08:58
4.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Now you're billed for minutes that never happen. The calm is the product."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Visual metaphor: a sleek luxury product box on a pedestal labeled "CALM", with a soft glow and a price tag reading "$15,000 / year", empty clock faces floating around it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphor close-up. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: serene, commodified.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphor close-up	warm natural light with amber accents	serene, commodified	the box glowing

118
BEAT
09:02
5.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"At $2 million, you don't pay for treatment. You pay for the phone number."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist holding up his phone, the contact card "DR. — MOBILE" on screen with a glowing gold border, a price tag hanging from the phone. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: access, power.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	warm natural light with amber accents	access, power	holding the phone up

Notes · Chapter 5

CHAPTER 6 OF 9 · BEATS 119–135 · 09:08

Level 6 · $25 Million

The bill becomes a spreadsheet row

OUTFIT: a dark tailored jacket over a black tee · LIGHT: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows

119
BEAT
09:08
5.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Level six, $25 million. The bill doesn't come to you at all. Your knee wears out.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in a dark tailored jacket in a luxury penthouse hallway, a stack of mail being carried away by a staff member before he can touch it, a framed artwork reading "LEVEL 6 · $25,000,000". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: insulated.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	insulated	watching the mail leave

120
BEAT
09:13
3.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Old ankle, bad landing, a body that kept score.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting on a designer chair rubbing his knee, a faint translucent overlay of his old ankle screws and the basketball court fall glowing over the leg. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: aging, accumulated.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	aging, accumulated	rubbing the knee

121
BEAT
09:17
4.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“You have it replaced at a private surgical hospital two states away. A plane.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist stepping out of a small private jet onto a sunlit tarmac, a black car waiting, a modern private surgical hospital visible on a hill in the distance. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: smooth, elite.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	smooth, elite	descending the stairs

122
BEAT
09:22
2.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"A car at the bottom of the stairs."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
A black car with a uniformed driver holding the door open at the bottom of the jet stairs, the protagonist walking toward it with a cane. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: seamless.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	seamless	the driver opening the door

123
BEAT
09:24
3.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"A suite with a nurse who knocks before she enters. You sign nothing."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
A luxury hospital suite with a wood floor, a large window, and fresh flowers, a nurse in crisp navy scrubs knocking politely at the open door, the protagonist in a bed. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: respectful, hushed.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	respectful, hushed	the nurse knocking

124
BEAT
09:27
5.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Someone signed for you weeks ago, in a steady hand, with your full name spelled correctly."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of a pre-signed admission form on a leather clipboard, the signature in elegant confident handwriting, the full name spelled out neatly. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: handled.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	handled	the elegant signature

125
BEAT
09:33
7.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"At level one, you signed with your left hand, and nobody looked. The price is $142,000."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
Split frame: the level-one protagonist scrawling with his left hand on a scratched tablet; the present protagonist resting with no pen at all, a pen untouched on the tray. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: cold fluorescent on the left, warm lamp light on the right. Mood: contrast.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	cold fluorescent on the left, warm lamp light on the right	contrast	the two hands

126
BEAT
09:40
3.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“You know that only because it shows up three weeks later as”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
A family office conference room with floor-to-ceiling windows, a staffer placing a printed monthly report on a long table. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: corporate, remote.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	corporate, remote	the report landing

127
BEAT
09:43
7.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“a single row in your family office's monthly report. Medical. $142,300.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of the monthly report's expense table with rows "Landscaping · $18,400", "Medical · $142,300", "Wine · $9,750", the medical line no bigger than the others. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: flattened, ordinary.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up insert	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	flattened, ordinary	the medical row between the others

128
BEAT
09:50
5.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Between landscaping and a wine order. That's the bill now. A line in someone else's spreadsheet.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Visual metaphor: a tiny hospital building drawn inside one spreadsheet cell, surrounded by cells containing a lawn and a wine bottle. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphor close-up. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: reduced.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphor close-up	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	reduced	the cell glowing faintly

129
BEAT
09:56
2.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“You don't hold it. You don't open it.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist's empty hands resting on a mahogany desk, no envelope, no paper, a single closed laptop. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: untouched.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	untouched	hands resting

130
BEAT

09:58
3.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“A person you pay is paid to make sure you never have to.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A personal accountant, a sharply dressed man in his forties with neat gray temples and wire glasses, opening a stack of envelopes at a side desk while the protagonist reads a book in the background. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: delegated.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	delegated	the accountant slicing envelopes

131
BEAT

10:01
5.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“On discharge day, the director of patient experience walks you to the car. She's warm.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Director of Patient Experience**

IMAGE PROMPT

The director of patient experience walking beside the protagonist under a covered hospital entrance toward a waiting black car, smiling warmly. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the director of patient experience is an elegant woman in her fifties with a silver pixie cut, a cream blazer and pearl stud earrings. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide tracking shot. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: warm, polished.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide tracking shot	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	warm, polished	walking side by side

132
BEAT

10:07
6.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“She asks about your recovery. Then, lightly, as the door opens, she mentions the hospital foundation.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Director of Patient Experience**

IMAGE PROMPT

The director leaning in slightly by the open car door, gesturing toward an architect's rendering on a tablet labeled "REHABILITATION CENTER". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the director of patient experience is an elegant woman in her fifties with a silver pixie cut, a cream blazer and pearl stud earrings. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: courting.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	courting	showing the rendering

133
BEAT
10:13
6.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"A new rehabilitation center. Naming opportunities. She hands you a card. Heavy stock. Embossed."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a heavy embossed card with gold foil reading "NAMING OPPORTUNITIES · HOSPITAL FOUNDATION", held between the director's manicured fingers. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: luxurious, persuasive.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	luxurious, persuasive	the card offered

134
BEAT
10:20
7.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Not an envelope with a window. An invitation. At $25 million, the hospital stops billing you."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Split frame: a cheap white envelope with a plastic window on the left; a heavy gold-embossed invitation card on the right, both addressed to the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: cold gray on the left, warm gold on the right. Mood: contrast.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	cold gray on the left, warm gold on the right	contrast	the two papers side by side

135
BEAT
10:27
2.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"It starts courting you."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in the back seat of the car holding the invitation, the hospital's glass front reflected in the window, a single rose on the seat beside him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows. Mood: flattered, wary.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	warm hotel-like lamp pools against cool blue windows	flattered, wary	turning the card over

Notes · Chapter 6

CHAPTER 7 OF 9 · BEATS 136–158 · 10:29

Level 7 · $200 Million

4,000 employees · The drawer of envelopes

OUTFIT: a dark tailored jacket over a black tee · LIGHT: rich golden light with deep soft shadows

136
BEAT
10:29
7.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Level seven, $200 million. You pay hospital bills for four thousand people. Your company is self-insured.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in a dark tailored jacket at the head of a glass boardroom table, a wall screen reading "EMPLOYEE HEALTH PLAN · 4,000 MEMBERS", a brass nameplate "LEVEL 7 · $200,000,000". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: responsible, powerful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	responsible, powerful	looking at the screen

137
BEAT
10:36
5.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Every employee's emergency room, every child's ear infection, every stone and sprain,”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: a vast mosaic of thousands of tiny employee portraits, each with a small medical icon — a stethoscope, an ear, a stone, a wrist splint. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide metaphor shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: vast, human.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide metaphor shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	vast, human	the mosaic filling the frame

138
BEAT
10:42
5.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“flows back to a spreadsheet you approve. Last year, $61 million in claims.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist reviewing a spreadsheet on a large monitor with a total cell reading "$61,000,000 · CLAIMS", the city skyline glowing outside. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: over-the-shoulder shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: heavy.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
over-the-shoulder shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	heavy	scrolling the totals

139
BEAT

10:48
6.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Your CFO walks you through it. She stops on one slide. Ancillary supplies. A single item."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The CFO**

IMAGE PROMPT

The CFO standing at the boardroom screen, pointing at a slide titled "ANCILLARY SUPPLIES" with one highlighted row. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the CFO is a composed woman in her forties with auburn hair in a sleek low bun and a charcoal suit, holding a tablet. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: analytical.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	analytical	pointing at the row

140
BEAT

10:54
6.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"3,112 ice bags. At $91 each. Then she proposes a change."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the slide's highlighted row: "ICE BAG · QTY 3,112 · UNIT $91.00", a small clear hospital ice bag with a blue twist tie icon beside it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: recurring, absurd.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up insert	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	recurring, absurd	the row pulsing

141
BEAT

11:01
9.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Raise the employee deductible to $6,000. Saves $4.1 million a year. Clean. Defensible. Industry standard."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The CFO**

IMAGE PROMPT

The CFO presenting a slide with a bar chart: "RAISE DEDUCTIBLE TO $6,000 · SAVES $4.1M/YR", a neat green arrow pointing down. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the CFO is a composed woman in her forties with auburn hair in a sleek low bun and a charcoal suit, holding a tablet. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot over the protagonist's shoulder. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: clean, cold.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot over the protagonist's shoulder	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	clean, cold	the chart appearing

142
BEAT
11:11
4.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You think about yourself, curled on a gurney at 4 a.m. Two envelopes."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A desaturated memory floating over the boardroom table: the protagonist curled on a gurney at 4 a.m., two envelopes on his chest. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with a translucent memory overlay. Lighting: rich golden boardroom light with a cold desaturated memory overlay. Mood: haunted.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot with a translucent memory overlay	rich golden boardroom light with a cold desaturated memory overlay	haunted	the memory hovering

143
BEAT
11:15
3.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"A month of rent for four millimeters. You say no."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist looking up from the table with a slight shake of his head, the green arrow on the slide dimming. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: quiet, firm.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	quiet, firm	shaking his head

144
BEAT
11:18
5.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"She nods and moves to the next slide. She doesn't ask why. You don't explain."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**, **The CFO**

IMAGE PROMPT

The CFO nodding without expression and clicking to the next slide, the protagonist silent in his chair. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the CFO is a composed woman in her forties with auburn hair in a sleek low bun and a charcoal suit, holding a tablet. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: unexplained.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	unexplained	the slide changing

145
BEAT

11:23
3.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"That spring, your mother mentions a lump. Casually. Over dinner."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, Mom**

IMAGE PROMPT

A warm, softly lit dinner table in a fine apartment, the protagonist's mother, now older and thinner, touching the side of her chest casually while passing a dish. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a woman in her sixties with gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: ominous, casual.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	ominous, casual	the mother touching her chest

146
BEAT

11:27
3.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You ask how long it's been there. She says a while. You ask how long."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, Mom**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist leaning toward his mother across the table, setting his fork down, his mother looking away and waving one hand dismissively. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a woman in her sixties with gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up two-shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: concerned.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up two-shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	concerned	leaning in

147
BEAT

11:31
4.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"She says since before Christmas. It's April. You could have flown her anywhere. Any surgeon."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mom**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the mother saying it quietly, a wall calendar behind her flipped to April with December circled in the past. Character notes: his mother is a woman in her sixties with gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: warm dinner light turning cooler. Mood: regretful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	warm dinner light turning cooler	regretful	looking down at her plate

148
BEAT

11:35
3.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Any city. That night. She knows that. She waited anyway."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: a private jet, a team of surgeons, and a hospital skyline floating above the protagonist's open hand like possibilities he could have given, all unused. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphor medium shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: powerless.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphor medium shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	powerless	staring at his open hand

149
BEAT
11:38
2.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"She said she didn't want to cost you anything."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mom**

IMAGE PROMPT

The mother folding her napkin carefully, a faint ghost of the white windowed envelope reflected in her water glass. Character notes: his mother is a woman in her sixties with gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: protective, sad.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	protective, sad	folding the napkin

150
BEAT
11:41
3.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"The best oncologist in the country sees her in two days."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, Mom**

IMAGE PROMPT

A gleaming oncology office with diplomas, a top oncologist, a woman in her sixties with silver hair in a white coat, reviewing scans with the protagonist and his mother. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a woman in her sixties with gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: clean cool clinical light. Mood: fast, serious.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	clean cool clinical light	fast, serious	reviewing scans

151
BEAT
11:45
5.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Everything moves at the speed of money. But it can't move backward. It can't reach December."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: a large clock on a hospital wall whose hands spin forward rapidly but are blocked by a wall of envelopes from turning backward to December. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphor close-up. Lighting: cool clinical light. Mood: irreversible.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphor close-up	cool clinical light	irreversible	the hands straining

152
BEAT
11:50
4.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Here's what nobody tells you. You can pay off every bill your mother will ever get."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in a hospital hallway holding a stack of paid bills, each stamped "PAID", while a shadowy price tag floats over his mother's head behind a glass window. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: cool clinical hallway light. Mood: helpless.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	cool clinical hallway light	helpless	holding the paid stack

153
BEAT

11:55
4.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You can't pay off the habit. The math she learned at level one never left."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mom**

IMAGE PROMPT
Flashback of the mother decades younger at a cramped kitchen table, sorting bills and adding numbers on a cheap calculator, her face set. Character notes: his mother is a woman in her sixties with gray-streaked dark hair in a low bun, round reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded mauve cardigan over a floral blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, desaturated. Lighting: desaturated, cold flashback light. Mood: learned fear.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, desaturated	desaturated, cold flashback light	learned fear	pressing calculator buttons

154
BEAT

11:59
3.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"It just waited in her for forty years. She dies in October."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
A quiet October bedroom with an empty bed, autumn leaves outside the window, the protagonist standing in the doorway in a dark jacket. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: pale gray autumn daylight. Mood: grief, silence.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot	pale gray autumn daylight	grief, silence	standing in the doorway

155
BEAT

12:03
6.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"In her kitchen drawer, you find envelopes. Dozens. White, with little windows. Every one stamped paid."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist opening a kitchen drawer in his mother's old kitchen, dozens of white envelopes with small plastic windows stacked neatly inside, each stamped "PAID". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: over-the-shoulder close-up. Lighting: pale gray daylight in an old kitchen. Mood: devastating.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
over-the-shoulder close-up	pale gray daylight in an old kitchen	devastating	opening the drawer

156
BEAT

12:09
2.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Every one paid by you. She kept them all."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of one envelope on top of the stack, the paid statement showing "Ice bag ... $91.00 · PAID", a paper clip holding a sticky note in her handwriting. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: pale gray daylight in an old kitchen. Mood: tender, heartbreaking.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up insert	pale gray daylight in an old kitchen	tender, heartbreaking	the note on the envelope

157
BEAT
12:12
3.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“At $200 million, you can buy anyone's care.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist sitting alone at his mother's small kitchen table with the drawer of envelopes, his tailored jacket draped over the chair. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: pale gray daylight in an old kitchen. Mood: grief, wealth.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	pale gray daylight in an old kitchen	grief, wealth	sitting with the envelopes

158
BEAT
12:16
4.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“You can't buy back the time they spent afraid of the price.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT
Visual metaphor: an hourglass filled with tiny envelopes instead of sand, a gold price tag hanging from it reading "NOT FOR SALE". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphor close-up. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: bitter, profound.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphor close-up	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	bitter, profound	the envelopes falling

Notes · Chapter 7

CHAPTER 8 OF 9 · BEATS 159–182 · 12:20

Level 8 · $1 Billion

The piano loop · Balance, zero

OUTFIT: a dark tailored jacket over a black tee · LIGHT: rich golden light with deep soft shadows

159
BEAT

12:20
6.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Level eight, $1 billion. You don't receive hospital bills. Hospitals send you proposals."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in a dark tailored jacket in a vast golden library-like home office, a desk piled with glossy proposals from hospitals, a carved wooden sign reading "LEVEL 8 · $1,000,000,000". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: immense.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	immense	walking toward the desk

160
BEAT

12:26
3.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Your own care is no longer billed. Your doctor is employed."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Household Physician**

IMAGE PROMPT

A private medical suite inside the protagonist's home, an employed physician in a white coat with a staff badge reading "HOUSEHOLD MEDICAL", setting up equipment. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the household physician is a man in his fifties with close-cropped gray hair and a trim beard, wearing a white coat over a dark sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: private, absolute.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	private, absolute	the physician arranging tools

161
BEAT

12:30
2.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Salary, benefits, an office in your house."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a payroll screen listing "Physician · Salary · Benefits" alongside "Chef" and "Driver", and a small door plaque reading "MEDICAL OFFICE". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: employed.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	employed	scrolling payroll

162
BEAT

12:32
2.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“When your wrist aches in the cold, the old sprain,”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at a tall window on a snowy evening flexing his right wrist, a faint glowing outline of the old foam splint around it. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: cool blue snowy window light with warm interior glow. Mood: old pain.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	cool blue snowy window light with warm interior glow	old pain	flexing the wrist

163
BEAT

12:35
3.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“she's there in nine minutes with an ice pack from your own freezer.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Household Physician**

IMAGE PROMPT

The household physician pressing a soft gel ice pack from a sleek stainless freezer onto the protagonist's wrist, a small clock showing nine minutes after the call. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the household physician is a man in his fifties with close-cropped gray hair and a trim beard, wearing a white coat over a dark sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: attentive, private.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	attentive, private	applying the ice pack

164
BEAT

12:39
1.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“That fall, at a gala,”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A grand gala ballroom with chandeliers, round tables and a banner reading "HOSPITAL FOUNDATION GALA", the protagonist entering in a dark tailored jacket. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: opulent.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	opulent	entering the ballroom

165
BEAT
12:41
4.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“the chief executive of the hospital where you once waited three hours”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Hospital CEO**

IMAGE PROMPT
The hospital chief executive approaching the protagonist through the crowd, arms already reaching out, a glass of champagne in a waiter's tray nearby. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the hospital chief executive is a tall man in his sixties with silver swept-back hair and a black tuxedo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: eager, courtly.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	eager, courtly	approaching with open arms

166
BEAT
12:45
2.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“and ten minutes shakes your hand with both of his.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Hospital CEO**

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of the chief executive shaking the protagonist's hand with both of his hands, a big practiced smile. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the hospital chief executive is a tall man in his sixties with silver swept-back hair and a black tuxedo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: ingratiating.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	ingratiating	the two-handed handshake

167
BEAT
12:47
4.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“He knows your net worth to the nearest hundred million. He doesn't know your wrist.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Hospital CEO**

IMAGE PROMPT
The chief executive smiling, a faint glowing figure "$1B" floating behind his eyes, while the protagonist's right wrist with its old faint scar is in the foreground unnoticed. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the hospital chief executive is a tall man in his sixties with silver swept-back hair and a black tuxedo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up with foreground detail. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: blind.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up with foreground detail	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	blind	the wrist unnoticed

168
BEAT
12:52
2.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“He tells you his door is always open.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Hospital CEO**

IMAGE PROMPT
The chief executive gesturing toward a tall ornate golden door in the background of the ballroom, light pouring from it. Character notes: the hospital chief executive is a tall man in his sixties with silver swept-back hair and a black tuxedo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: welcoming.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	welcoming	gesturing to the door

169
BEAT

12:54
4.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You remember a tablet turned toward you, and a box marked insurance."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A desaturated memory overlay above the gala: the scratched emergency-room tablet turned toward the protagonist with the blank "INSURANCE:" box outlined in red. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with memory overlay. Lighting: golden ballroom light with a cold desaturated memory overlay. Mood: haunted.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot with memory overlay	golden ballroom light with a cold desaturated memory overlay	haunted	the memory appearing

170
BEAT

12:59
6.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"A founder pitches you on a company that speeds up hospital billing. Better coding. Faster collections."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Founder**

IMAGE PROMPT

A sleek glass conference room where the founder presents a slide titled "REVENUE CYCLE · FASTER COLLECTIONS", the protagonist seated at the head of the table. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the founder is a man in his early thirties with curly blond hair, a navy blazer over a white tee and white sneakers. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: ambitious.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	ambitious	the founder pointing at the slide

171
BEAT

13:05
4.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Fewer write-offs. He's sharp. He laughs at your jokes a beat early."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Founder**

IMAGE PROMPT

The founder laughing a beat too early at something the protagonist said, the protagonist deadpan, an assistant glancing up. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the founder is a man in his early thirties with curly blond hair, a navy blazer over a white tee and white sneakers. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: ingratiating.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	ingratiating	the early laugh

172
BEAT
13:09
5.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"He plays a demo of their patient phone line. The piano starts. Fourteen seconds."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Founder**

IMAGE PROMPT

The founder placing a phone on the table playing a demo call, a translucent looping ribbon of piano notes rising from its speaker toward the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the founder is a man in his early thirties with curly blond hair, a navy blazer over a white tee and white sneakers. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: uneasy.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	uneasy	the music rising

173
BEAT
13:14
5.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"The note that never resolves. You haven't heard it in twenty years. Your hand goes cold."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the protagonist's face frozen, the ribbon of piano notes circling his head, the unresolved last note hanging, his fingers cold and pale on the table. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: shaken.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	shaken	freezing

174
BEAT
13:20
4.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You know exactly where it loops. You pass on the deal. You don't tell him why."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist, The Founder**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist closing the founder's leather proposal folder and sliding it back across the table, the founder's smile faltering. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the founder is a man in his early thirties with curly blond hair, a navy blazer over a white tee and white sneakers. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: decisive, silent.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	decisive, silent	sliding the folder back

175
BEAT
13:25
4.8s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Instead, you do something else. Medical debt sells for about a penny on the dollar."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist studying a dense spreadsheet titled "MEDICAL DEBT PORTFOLIO · FACE VALUE $40,000,000 · PRICE $0.01 PER $1". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: over-the-shoulder close-up. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: calculated mercy.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
over-the-shoulder close-up	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	calculated mercy	studying the numbers

176
BEAT

13:29
6.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You buy $40 million of it for $400,000. Less than the painting in your hallway."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist standing in his grand hallway before a large framed painting, a small price card beside it reading "$400,000", a contract for the debt in his hand. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: ironic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	ironic	comparing contract and painting

177
BEAT

13:36
3.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Then you forgive all of it. Letters go out. Thousands of them."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT
The protagonist signing a single document with a fountain pen, and outside the window a fleet of mail trucks pulling away from a vast mail-sorting facility. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: quietly enormous.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	quietly enormous	signing the page

178
BEAT

13:39
6.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"White envelopes with little plastic windows. A name in capitals in every one. Inside, one line."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT
A mail-sorting facility conveyor belt carrying thousands of white envelopes with small plastic windows, each showing a name in black capitals. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: mass, hopeful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	mass, hopeful	envelopes streaming

179
BEAT

13:46
4.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Balance, zero. It changes everything for the people who open them."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of a letter unfolded in a stranger's hands in a dim kitchen: "BALANCE: $0.00". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: dim cool kitchen light. Mood: relief, disbelief.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up insert	dim cool kitchen light	relief, disbelief	the letter unfolding

180
BEAT
13:50
4.9s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"It changes nothing about the envelopes that will be printed next month. You know that."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: a giant industrial printer spitting out an endless stream of new white windowed envelopes labeled "NEXT MONTH", unaffected. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide metaphor shot. Lighting: harsh cool industrial light. Mood: systemic, cold.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide metaphor shot	harsh cool industrial light	systemic, cold	the printer running

181
BEAT
13:55
4.4s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You do it anyway. At $1 billion, you don't pay hospital bills."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist standing by a tall window at dusk, a single forgiveness letter in his hand, golden light on his deadpan face. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a dark tailored jacket over a black tee, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up, protagonist off-center left. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: resolved, small.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up, protagonist off-center left	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	resolved, small	looking out the window

182
BEAT
13:59
3.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"You decide which ones stop existing."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Visual metaphor: a giant golden eraser rubbing out rows of hospital bills on a long ledger, some bills vanishing, many more remaining. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphor close-up. Lighting: rich golden light with deep soft shadows. Mood: power, limit.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphor close-up	rich golden light with deep soft shadows	power, limit	the eraser moving

Notes · Chapter 8

CHAPTER 9 OF 9 · BEATS 183–194 · 14:02

Outro · Somewhere Right Now

A stranger · "Balance due."

OUTFIT: a plain black hoodie with the hood up · LIGHT: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows

183
BEAT
14:02
1.3s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Somewhere right now,"*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Stranger**

IMAGE PROMPT

A small dim apartment kitchen with an old white fridge, a cracked linoleum floor, and the stranger standing in the doorway in the evening. Character notes: the stranger is a young woman in her twenties with a messy dark bun, an oversized faded olive hoodie and a gray foam splint on her right wrist, her face tired. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: bleak, quiet.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	bleak, quiet	standing in the doorway

184
BEAT
14:03
5.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"someone is standing in a kitchen holding a white envelope with a little plastic window."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Stranger**

IMAGE PROMPT

The stranger holding a white envelope with a small clear plastic window up to the flickering kitchen light. Character notes: the stranger is a young woman in her twenties with a messy dark bun, an oversized faded olive hoodie and a gray foam splint on her right wrist, her face tired. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: dread.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	dread	holding the envelope

185
BEAT
14:08
4.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *"Their name sits inside it in capitals. Their wrist is wrapped in a foam splint."*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Stranger**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the stranger's right wrist wrapped in a gray foam splint with velcro straps, the envelope's window showing a name in black capitals. Character notes: the stranger is a young woman in her twenties with a messy dark bun, an oversized faded olive hoodie and a gray foam splint on her right wrist, her face tired. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: mirrored.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	mirrored	the splinted wrist

186
BEAT
14:13
5.6s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“It isn't even broken. They read one line four times. Ice bag, ninety-one dollars.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Stranger**

IMAGE PROMPT
Close-up of the itemized bill in the stranger's hand, the line "ICE BAG ... $91.00" circled by her thumb. Character notes: the stranger is a young woman in her twenties with a messy dark bun, an oversized faded olive hoodie and a gray foam splint on her right wrist, her face tired. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: absurd, mirrored.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	absurd, mirrored	rereading the line

187
BEAT
14:19
3.5s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“A bag of frozen peas is $1.89.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Stranger**

IMAGE PROMPT
The stranger's open freezer showing a bag of frozen peas with a "$1.89" price sticker. Character notes: the stranger is a young woman in her twenties with a messy dark bun, an oversized faded olive hoodie and a gray foam splint on her right wrist, her face tired. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: absurd.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	absurd	looking at the peas

188
BEAT
14:22
3.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“They stick it to the fridge with a magnet from a place that closed.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Stranger**

IMAGE PROMPT
The stranger pinning the envelope to the old white fridge with a faded red pizza-slice magnet from a closed pizza place. Character notes: the stranger is a young woman in her twenties with a messy dark bun, an oversized faded olive hoodie and a gray foam splint on her right wrist, her face tired. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: resigned.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	resigned	sliding the magnet down

189
BEAT
14:26
5.0s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“They call the number. Fourteen seconds of piano. They'll hear it eleven times.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Stranger**

IMAGE PROMPT
The stranger sitting on the kitchen floor against the fridge, phone on speaker showing "ON HOLD 00:14", a ribbon of piano notes looping above her. Character notes: the stranger is a young woman in her twenties with a messy dark bun, an oversized faded olive hoodie and a gray foam splint on her right wrist, her face tired. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, low angle. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: trapped, waiting.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot, low angle	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	trapped, waiting	staring at the timer

190
BEAT

14:31
4.7s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Nobody in that building is cruel. The coder, the clerk, the man with the script.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
A montage-style wide shot of a hospital billing office at night: a tired medical coder, a clerk at a registration window, and a call-center rep reading a script, each lit by their own screen. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cold blue screen light in a dark office. Mood: indifferent, human.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot	cold blue screen light in a dark office	indifferent, human	each working quietly

191
BEAT

14:36
4.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“Everyone is doing their job. And the job is the envelope.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Visual metaphor: a long conveyor belt of identical white windowed envelopes moving past the tired workers, who each stamp them without looking up. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide metaphor shot. Lighting: harsh cool industrial light. Mood: systemic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide metaphor shot	harsh cool industrial light	systemic	the stamping

192
BEAT

14:40
5.2s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“The doctor's hands are nearly the same at every level. The X-ray is the same X-ray.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Split frame: the same doctor's gloved hands examining two different wrists, one in a black hoodie sleeve and one in a tailored jacket sleeve, and an X-ray image identical on both sides. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: cold fluorescent on the left, warm gold on the right. Mood: equal care.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	cold fluorescent on the left, warm gold on the right	equal care	the identical X-rays

193
BEAT

14:45
4.1s

☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

> *“The ice bag is the same ice bag. The bill is what changes.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Split frame: the same clear plastic hospital ice bag with a blue twist tie on both sides, but on the left a cheap envelope with a plastic window, and on the right a gold embossed card. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen composition. Lighting: cold fluorescent on the left, warm gold on the right. Mood: stark contrast.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen composition	cold fluorescent on the left, warm gold on the right	stark contrast	the bills diverging

194
BEAT

14:49
4.3s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

> *“And the bill decides who you become. Balance due.”*

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT
Final shot: the white envelope with a small plastic window pinned under the faded red pizza-slice magnet on an old fridge, the words "BALANCE DUE" printed in red, the kitchen light flickering. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows. Mood: cold, final.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up insert	harsh cool fluorescent light with a faint flicker, blue-gray shadows	cold, final	the light flickering once

Notes · Chapter 9